

The Apostles that Turned?

Authoritarian Successor Parties and Democratic Backsliding

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The Puzzle

- Authoritarian successor parties (ASPs) often credited with **stabilizing** young democracies
- **Optimistic account:** reinvented ASPs anchor democratic party systems Grzymala-Busse (2002, 2020); Miller (2021); Loxton & Mainwaring (2018); Riedl (2014)
- **BUT**, Hungary, Nicaragua, South Korea, Bolivia — ASPs as agents of democratic erosion
- **Research question:** When do ASPs undermine rather than support democracy?

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Argument: When Apostles Bite Back

- ASPs are vote-seeking organizations: survival drives behavior
- Electoral decline does not always produce dissolution; it can produce adaptation/resistance
- When cornered, they revert to anti-pluralism: dog-whistling, anti-pluralism, and most importantly alliances with populists

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- ASP: electoral declines → Anti-pluralism → backsliding
 - ▶ The pro-democracy effect of reinvented ASPs on backsliding is conditional on electoral status.

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Empirical Strategy (Quantitative Context + BPT)

- Two-stage design:
 - ▶ **Cross-national:** Cox PH models (empirical scope calibration)
 - ▶ **Within-case:** Bayesian process tracing of South Korea (mechanism testing)
- Data: Grzymala-Busse (2020) × V-Party × ERT × V-Dem
- 81 countries, 1945–2015

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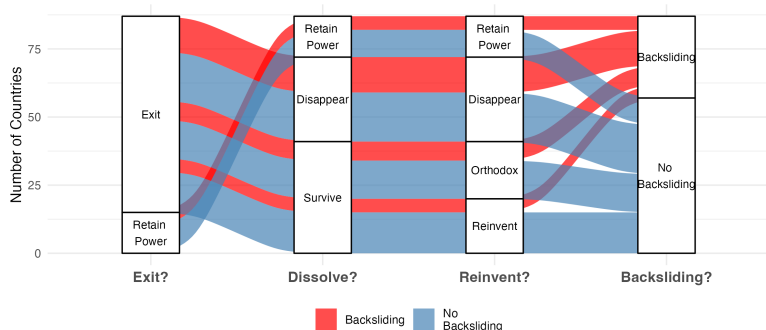
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ASP Fate and Backsliding: Descriptive



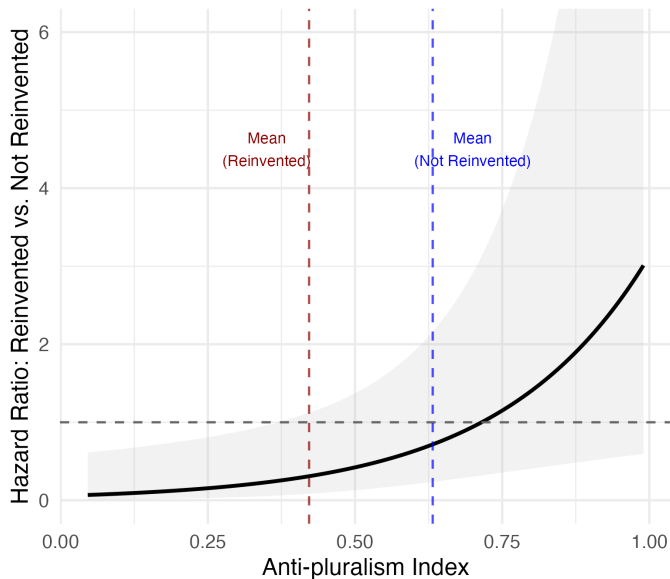
- Reinvented ASPs: minority of cases, non-negligible share of backsliding

Cox PH Estimates

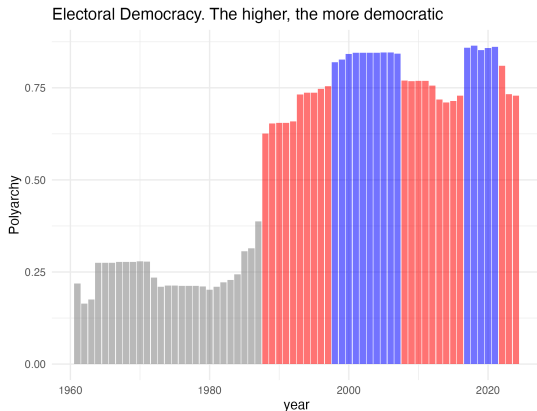
	Model 1 Baseline	Model 2 Controls
Reinvented	0.057** [0.005, 0.656]	0.095* [0.006, 1.446]
Anti-pluralism	0.479 [0.060, 3.800]	0.593 [0.048, 7.384]
Reinvented $\times$ Anti-plur.	55.14** [1.72, 1768]	192.51** [2.92, 12706]
Polyarchy		0.353 [0.011, 11.3]
ln(GDP per capita)		0.419* [0.249, 0.708]
Num. Obs.	539	539
Concordance	0.703	0.769

Hazard ratios with 95% CI in brackets. SEs clustered by country.

Conditional Effect



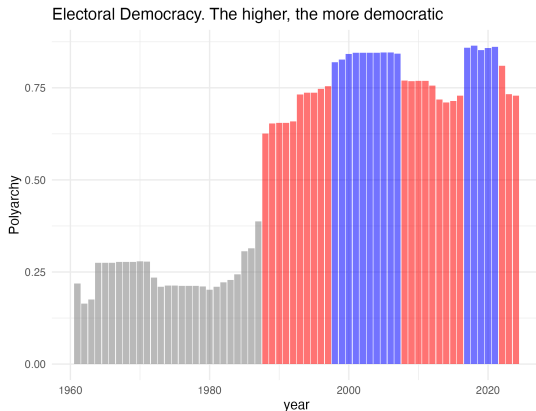
Case: South Korea



• DJP → DLP → NKP → GNP → Saenuri → PPP

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Hypotheses and Priors

Hypothesis	Prior	Justification
H (Apostle)	0.3	<i>Moderate</i> cross-national support
A ₁ (Demand-side: 'people wanted it')	0.35	Fairly strong support from comparative behavioral literature
A ₂ (Institutional: 'Korean democracy weak')	0.35	Fairly strong support from comparative institutional literature

- The absolute numerical values (prior) don't really matter.
- The relative size matters more.
- How they are **updated** matters the most.

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Summary of Evidential Tests

OI	Test Type	Hs	Predicted Evidence
<i>H₁: Electoral Decline → Anti-pluralist Turn</i>			
OI ₁	Hoop	H ₁	right sequence
OI ₂	Smoking Gun	H ₁	evidence of adopting anti-pluralism
<i>H₂: Anti-pluralistic Turn → Facilitation of Populist Outsider</i>			
OI ₃	Hoop	H ₂	right sequence
OI ₄	Smoking Gun	H ₂	Outsider's reliance on ASP
<i>H₃: Alliance → Executive Aggrandizement</i>			
OI ₅	Hoop	H ₃	institutional 'necessary condition'
OI ₆	Smoking Gun	H ₃	specific legislation/institutional support
<i>Alternative Hypotheses</i>			
OI _{A1a}	Hoop for A ₁	!A ₁	right sequence
OI _{A1b}	Discriminating	!A ₁	no causal reversal
OI _{A2}	Discriminating	!A ₂	Non-ASP govt, no backsliding

Evidential Test (OI₁): South Korean Election Results

Year	Legislative Election Winner	Seat Share (Winning Party %)	Presidential Election Winner
1987			
1988	<i>Democratic Justice Party</i>	125/299 (41.8)	<i>Kim Young-sam</i>
1992	<i>Democratic Liberal Party</i>	149/299 (49.8)	
1996	<i>New Korea Party</i>	139/299 (46.5)	
1997			Kim Dae-jung
2000	<i>Grand National Party</i>	133/273 (48.7)	Roh Moo-hyun
2002			
2004	Uri Party	152/299 (50.8)	<i>Lee Myung-bak</i>
2007			
2008	<i>Grand National Party</i>	153/299 (51.2)	<i>Park Geun-hye</i>
2012	<i>Saenuri Party</i>	152/300 (50.7)	
2016	Democratic Party of Korea	123/300 (41.0)	Moon Jae-in
2017			
2020	Democratic Party of Korea	180/300 (60.0)	<i>Yoon Suk-yeol</i>
2022			
2024	Democratic Party of Korea	175/300 (58.3)	

Likelihood Assignments

- Clear support: anti-pluralism did NOT precede electoral declines.
- Fair support: electoral declines preceded anti-pluralism.
- 'higher-than-random but not too high' chance for H_1

Ol	$P(E H)$	$P(E A_1)$	$P(E A_2)$
Ol ₁	0.75	0.5	0.5
Ol ₂			
Ol ₃			
Ol ₄			
Ol ₅			
Ol ₆			
Ol _{A1a}			
Ol _{A1b}			
Ol _{A2}			

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Calculate normalized posterior using Bayes Rule

$$\begin{aligned} P(H | E) &= \frac{P(E | H) P(H)}{P(E | H) P(H) + P(E | A_1) P(A_1) + P(E | A_2) P(A_2)} \\ &= \frac{(0.75)(0.30)}{(0.75)(0.30) + (0.50)(0.35) + (0.50)(0.35)} \\ &= \frac{0.225}{0.575} \approx 0.391 \end{aligned}$$

Posterior Probabilities

Step	$P(H \mid E)$	$P(A_1 \mid E)$	$P(A_2 \mid E)$
<i>Prior</i>	<i>0.30</i>	<i>0.35</i>	<i>0.35</i>
Ol_1	0.391	0.304	0.304
Ol_2			
Ol_3			
Ol_4			
Ol_5			
Ol_6			
Ol_{A1a}			
Ol_{A1b}			
Ol_{A2}			

Contribution

- Reconceptualizes ASPs as **conditionally** destabilizing
- Integrates party-level dynamics into backsliding theory
- Bridges two bodies of literature that have developed in isolation:
 - ▶ ASP / democratic consolidation
 - ▶ Contemporary democratic backsliding
- Policy implication: the most effective democratic gatekeepers can become its most dangerous saboteurs when cornered